

have an instinctive ability to recognize and predict visual price patterns. Five charts into the game, he was able to conclude that I was not one of these individuals. It would be years before I would look at another chart.

In my junior year of high school, I would meet my first Market Wizard, John Bender. I had suggested to my father that we take a trip before I left for college. My dad is always game for an adventure. Several years earlier he had disappeared on a hike up Mount Temple in the Canadian Rockies. Instead of the simple day hike he told us he was departing on, he came back 12 hours later with frostbite, having decided to summit the mountain instead. I thought it best that we go someplace warm this time. John Bender had just retired from trading and used his gains to buy up thousands of acres of Costa Rican rain forest. He invited us to stay at a guesthouse on the reserve.

We arranged for an SUV to drive us four hours from San Jose up to John's reserve in the rain forest. Our car made its way up a winding, single-lane dirt road, at the top of which was a clearing with two heavily armed men. John's reserve was patrolled by guards to prevent poaching. The property had three residences (one under construction) set on a large, grassy plateau. One was the existing main house, in which John resided with his wife, Ann, while they built their spectacular, multilevel, 360-degree-view dream house on the edge of the plateau. We settled into the third dwelling, the guesthouse, and agreed to meet John for a drink once we unpacked.

John was sitting on his lightly landscaped porch, overlooking the rain forest below, beers in hand. We talked for hours as the sun set over the edge of the rain forest. John led most of the conversation. He had lots of energy, as if he had so much to say and had just been waiting for the right person to talk to. The conversation ranged from the paradoxes presented by quantum physics experiments to John's particular disgust for one fund manager, who he insisted was a fraud. I wouldn't hear that manager's name again for nine years, when the financial crisis exposed what John had known all along: Bernie Madoff was a fraud.

College was quickly approaching. I went down to my dad's office to seek his advice on a major. It's quite embarrassing to say, but at this point, I had still not read *Market Wizards*. I had no involvement with the markets, and my father was never one to push anyone toward his own desires. I told him